

Guitar Strumming Mechanics

Strumming controls your rhythm, tempo, and dynamics. Good strumming technique relies on keeping your wrist loose rather than stiffening your entire arm.

1. Holding the Pick (Plectrum)

- Hold the pick between your thumb and the side of your index finger.
- Leave about a quarter inch (0.5cm) of the pointed tip sticking out.
- Keep your grip firm enough that the pick won't fly out, but loose enough so it can glide smoothly over the strings without catching.

2. Proper Arm Motion

- **Wrist Rotation:** The strumming motion comes primarily from a loose, rotating wrist (like shaking water off your hand), not from stiffly moving your elbow or shoulder.
- **Continuous Motion:** Keep your arm moving steadily up and down in a constant rhythm—even when you aren't hitting the strings on a specific beat.

3. Basic Rhythm Notation & Patterns

Music is counted in beats. In standard 4/4 time, you count **1 - 2 - 3 - 4** for downstrums, and use **"and"** (&) for upstrums (**1 & 2 & 3 & 4 &**).

Pattern Name	Counting Guide	Motion Sequence
Basic All-Downs	1 - 2 - 3 - 4	Down, Down, Down, Down
Alternating Eighths	1 & 2 & 3 & 4 &	Down-Up, Down-Up, Down-Up, Down-Up
Pop / Folk Pattern	1 - 2 & - & 4 &	Down, Down-Up, (miss), Up-Down-Up

Practice Tip: Always practice strumming patterns slowly with a metronome set to 60–70 BPM before increasing your speed.